

■ Device Affordance

■ What is it?

People interact based on what feels natural for their device.

Users expect different behaviors depending on the device they're using.

For example, on mobile we expect to swipe, while on desktop we expect to click or hover.

■■ History

The idea comes from **affordance theory** by psychologist **James J. Gibson (1977)**. He described affordances as the “clues” objects give about how they should be used.

Later, designer **Don Norman (1988)** applied it to products and interfaces—arguing that good design makes intended actions obvious.

Today, device affordance is critical in UX because people carry expectations from past experiences with devices.

■ The Psychology Behind It

- Device size, shape, and interface **signal how to interact**.
- Past experience with similar devices shapes behavior.
- If expectations aren't met, users feel confused or frustrated.

For example, if a mobile app requires hovering (a desktop behavior), users won't know what to do.

■■ Why It Matters

Ignoring device affordance can cause:

- Confused or frustrated users
- Higher bounce rates
- Misclicks or accidental actions
- Failed tasks due to mismatched behavior

■ How to Apply It

- **Design for each device** → shorter forms on mobile, full tools on desktop.
- **Use responsive design** → adapt layouts to fit screens naturally.
- **Provide visual cues** → arrows, shadows, or micro-interactions.
- **Test affordances** → can people tell what's clickable, swipeable, or tappable?
- **Keep gestures intuitive** → match platform standards (swipe on mobile, click on desktop).

■ Theory in Action

- **Instagram** uses swipe gestures for stories on mobile, but arrows on desktop, aligning with user expectations.
- **Self-checkout kiosks** mimic ATM layouts so users instantly know how to use them.

■ Final Thought

People do what feels natural for the device in their hands. When design matches device expectations, users barely need to think—the product just works.

Good design adapts to context, making experiences smooth and effortless.